

Windows Live SkyDrive: 500 MB—For Now

Microsoft has unveiled Windows Live SkyDrive, their new online storage service—currently available only for users in the US, the UK, and India! File sharing options are featured—such as Personal and Public—along with password protection. Visit skydrive.live.com. It's very user-friendly.



India Now Nokia's Second-Largest Market

India has overtaken the United States in the second quarter of 2007 to become Nokia's second-biggest market by sales, after China. The company shipped 60 million handsets from its factory near Chennai in the 18 months to August. Demand is expected to remain strong.



Enter



Jan Blom,
Head of the Nokia Satellite Design Studio, India

Nokia recently set up the first in a series of satellite design studios here in India. We caught up with Jan Blom, Head of Nokia Satellite Design Studio, India, for a tête-à-tête.

What role will the Indian Design Studio play in the context of designing phones for Nokia? Will you design future mobiles specifically for the Indian market or also for a global audience?

Jan Blom: The main objective of the programme is to bring us closer to local cultures and traditions, helping us find new ideas that can be implemented across our global portfolio of products.

How do you see Internet services shaping up on mobiles here?

Jan Blom: Internet usage on the mobile phone is the new megatrend. We are looking at what people want to do with mobile phones—sharing and creating content and building personalised networks.

What have you observed regarding Indian mobile usage habits and handset features preferred by Indians?

Jan Blom: We have conducted a lot of research into how cultures and traditions in India translate into colour and materials / texture preferences. Vibrant colours—reds and blues are important right now—signify a rich cultural identity and help your phone to be noticed. Metallic colours reinforce status in India. Silvers, Blacks, Golds, and metallic finishes are popular because of a strong link to a heritage of craftsmanship and artisans. Right now, it's all about colour. We are now looking at what colours will be in vogue next year and the year after that...

Indian consumers are looking at simple ways to navigate menus, so Nokia has introduced a one-touch feature for the music, Internet, camera, and GPS options.

VULNERABILITY 2.0

They're Invading Your Space

A majority of broadband users “share” music both legally and illegally and watch YouTube videos. No one thinks they could be doing something potentially dangerous; turns out, it could be. Hacking pranks—and even serious attacks—are in the news in a fairly big way, probably for the first time.

The BlackHat conference, a gathering of computer protection professionals, was held in Las Vegas in the first week of August. Security specialists demonstrated serious vulnerabilities in social networking sites. This means cause for concern for everyone.

MySpace users, for example, customise their pages with various layouts, CSS, and HTML code. Unscrupulous hackers take advantage of poorly-written code, and inject malicious code into such pages. These aren't “real” hackers—this kind of hacking is all too easy.

Rick Deacon, a network administrator (and a benign hacker) in Ohio, discovered a “zero-day” flaw in MySpace. This is a security vulnerability that becomes publicly known immediately after the attack happens. The flaw allows intruders to take command of personal Web pages.

Clones of popular social networking sites provide streaming media, and the facility to share that content with others.



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

Many small- and medium-sized social networking start-ups centred on the streaming of audio-visual content are cropping up. User-generated content that social networking sites offer could now turn out to be a threat. Malicious code can even be injected into files streamed from such sites. According to David Thiel, iSEC researcher, “Stream formats are good for containing exploit code and are quite dangerous because of the widespread use of it with kids online these days.”

Incidentally, at last year's Black Hat conference, security professionals revealed how hackers Bad Code using RSS feeds.

Then, hackers and security professionals have talked about the vulnerabilities in social networking sites due to cross site scripting loopholes—this is for those who know what CSS is. We can't go into the

details here, but suffice it to say it's a bad thing.

The problem exists even at the browser level: CSS loopholes have been found in older versions of Firefox. Opera recently fixed a JavaScript flaw using a Firefox tool (!) called Fuzzer.

Millions of people who frequent social networking sites don't even have an anti-virus installed—or at least don't regularly update their virus definitions.

Web 2.0 stands tall on the trust model with

user-generated content. If that trust is going to be subject to exploit code, where do we go from here? On a non-technical note, what's frustrating is that what the bad folks are doing is just for fun, just for cheap thrills, pure and simple.

THE VIEW FROM THE MOUNTAIN

There's G In The Air

This is yet another Google tale that must be told. The (US) Federal Communications Commission's (FCC) wireless 700 MHz band auction to take place on 16th January 2008 was announced in July of this year. Google, as we learn, has intentions of stepping into the mobile advertising market—and the announcement was